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Investigating quality education in mother tongue: Ensuring children's rights to access and equity schooling

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ABSTRACT

Mother-tongue education is an absolute precondition of equitable access to quality education, especially in multilingual settings. Its benefits are well established, yet many education systems continue to systematically marginalize effective mother-tongue instruction, thus denying the rights of linguistically diverse learners. This article investigates the importance of mother-tongue-based education for providing optimum learning environments and children's rights to inclusive and equitable schooling. It draws theoretical frameworks from Linguistic Human Rights, Interdependence Hypothesis, Critical Pedagogy and Language Planning Orientations to argue eloquently for mother tongue-related considerations within education policy. It argues that learning through a child's first language enhances performance, promotes cultural identity, and helps in cognitive and socio-emotional development. The article also firmly positions mother-tongue education as essential for upholding children's linguistic rights, promoting social cohesion, and sustaining cultural diversity. The findings show there is an urgent need to solidify mother-tongue education systems further, as this deliberate policy implementation will be a momentous step towards fostering genuine equity in learning environments where children may thrive and reach their full potential.

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1. Introduction

Quality education in the mother tongue is a basic right that has to be secured for all children. The Global Education Monitoring Report Team (UNESCO, 2016) noted, for example, that mother tongue education is necessary to ensure quality learning that is inclusive and equitable in correspondence with Sustainable Development Goals 4 (SDG 4) in Education. Many studies show that children's learning in their first language improves cognitive development and future academic success (Ball, 2011). Besides individual empowerment, mother tongue education strengthens social cohesion and keeps languages alive, and it keeps against the global decline of indigenous and minority languages (Skutnabb-Kangas & May, 2016). McCarthy and Nicholas (2014) argue that linguistic rights, which refer to language revival efforts, are foundational to building national identity and self-determination, especially for indigenous or marginalized communities. Scholars frequently frame these processes using terms such as reclamation, revitalization, regeneration, and regensis. All these terms are used to describe the efforts made to restore endangered languages back into active community use.

Research consistently demonstrates that children are taught best in a language they understand well; it is their mother tongue (Cummins, 2000; Malone, 2007, 2020). These authors further stated that mother-tongue education makes way for complete potential unlocking for children and helps nurture their own identities by providing a more holistic and equitable educational environment. Providing education through mother tongues instruction plays a critical strategy in furthering the Sustainable

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Development Goals, particularly Goal 4's commitment to ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education for all by 2030 (United Nations, 2015). Mother-tongue education has been proven to improve children's cognitive development while discouraging dropout rates and assisting in keeping cultural identity, especially in multicultural contexts like Africa (Ball, 2015; Heugh, 2019; UNESCO, 2016).

Education Policies that discourage linguistic diversity perpetuate inequality, evidenced by the low literacy outcomes when instruction neglects learners' primary languages (Global Partnership for Education, 2015). Access to education in one's mother tongue not only improves the effectiveness of education but also supports the preservation of cultural identity and diversity. In addition to all of the evidence gathered regarding the benefits of using the mother tongue in education, Grin (2003) identified the need for investment in education systems that would facilitate mother-tongue education. This is because of better learning outcomes and increased educational accessibility for disadvantaged populations. Moreover, Cummins (2000) argues that through mother-tongue instruction, cognitive development and the language proficiency that are fundamental to academic achievement are achieved. Research has challenged the conventional idea of monolingualism in language teaching by demonstrating how languages interact dynamically as learning unfolds (Cummins, 2017). The research also showed that moving beyond the isolation of target languages, effective bilingual education will make possible cross-linguistic transfer in the area of literacy development. Cummins (2017) argues that recognizing students' full linguistic repertoire creates more effective multilingual instructional strategies rather than restricting instruction to a single language approach. This approach not only validates children's existing language skills but also bridges the gap between monolingual and plurilingual paradigms in education.

Studies have shown how colonial language policies have systematically marginalized indigenous languages through education systems, serving as instruments in cultural assimilation and consolidation of power (McCarty, 2018; Ndhlovu & Makalela, 2021). Contemporary research underscores how the historical impositions have continued to perpetuate linguistic inequalities within postcolonial education systems (Erling & Seargeant, 2013; Piller, 2016). In essence, mother tongue-based quality education embodies linguistic inclusion while advancing the foundational principles of educational excellence, fairness, equity and social justice. It aimed at creating an inclusive environment that really can have every child succeed. Supporting children's home language education is vital for not only better academic performance but also human rights, empowerment, social cohesion, and cultural diversity preservation (UNESCO, 2025).

This article, thus, investigates mother tongue-based education (MTBE) through three theoretical frameworks: linguistic human rights (language access as an entitlement), the interdependence hypothesis (cognitive benefits of L1 instruction), and critical pedagogy (challenging linguistic power structures). The article demonstrates how quality MTBE: (1) fulfils fundamental educational rights, (2) enhances learning through cognitive transfer, and (3) empowers marginalized communities by centering their linguistic and cultural capitals. Drawing global case studies and systematic literature reviews, the analysis offers policy recommendations aligning MTBE with SDG 4 and children's rights, positioning it as essential for equitable, decolonial education.

1.1. Concept of mother tongue in education

1.1.1. Concept of the mother tongue: Linguistic and cultural dimensions

A Mother Tongue refers to children's first language or the languages acquired naturally in early childhood through familial and communal interactions. It is of great importance to the individual and the community because it holds profound cultural, emotional, psychological and cognitive significance, serving as both a cornerstone of individual identity and a vital thread in the sociocultural fabric of communities (Cummins, 2000; Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000). Having been acquired within the immediate surroundings of home in childhood, it becomes extremely personal, cultural-historical (UNESCO, 2003). The concept encompasses both self-identification within and social recognition from outside oneself (John, 2009), serving as the bedrock of cultural diversity that needs to be conserved for world peace (UNESCO, 2003).

1.1.2. Cognitive and pedagogical importance of learning in L1

The mother tongue serves as a platform of cognitive and linguistic development, which enables children to process information, voice thoughts, and has meaningful interactions in their environment (Cummins, 2000). Education in the mother tongue plays a vital role in children's cultural and academic development. By learning in their native language, children gain a deeper understanding of their cultural heritage while simultaneously forming their fundamental worldview (García, 2009). This linguistic foundation not only preserves cultural identity but also serves as a powerful educational tool, demonstrably accelerating literacy acquisition and improving overall school performance (UNESCO, 2003). For educational purposes, the mother tongue acts as an essential interconnector for the progression to learning further languages and contents in scholarship (Cummins, 2000).

Besides cultural and social meanings, the mother tongue is very important as a marker of personal and social identity, at the same time, a vehicle for social cohesion (UNESCO, 2003). It reflects trans-generational knowledge systems as well as native practices (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000), and it empowers linguistically, culturally and academically disadvantaged segments of society (May, 2014). The irrefutable connection that language shares with identity creates distinct links to which, in turn, individual self-concept and communal bonds may be fortified.

The recognition of mother tongue rights today cuts across educational policy and plays a vital human right attached to dignity and integration into society (Madonsela, 2012). In essence, these rights to language deserve some form of conservation concerning social justice and inclusive developmental environments. Mother-tongue speakers can look at the significance of the language from different angles: firstly, as a cognitive instrument through which children learn by processing information and acquiring literacy skills; secondly, as a means of cultural preservation and identity sustenance through indigenous knowledge systems; thirdly, as the bedrock of social cohesion across generations through tradition transmission; fourthly, language as a right which constitutes basic human dignity and equitable social engagement. It is through these interdependent perspectives that one can understand how mother tongue proficiency operates within the personal, communal, and societal domains and the implications such use carries for education, cultural continuity, and perspective on human rights.

1.1.3. Historical evolution of mother tongue in global education policies

The place of mother tongue in education has changed along different historical tracks. The colonial education system systematically left out indigenous languages, focusing almost exclusively on imperial languages. This linguistic hierarchy entrenched the perceived superiority of colonial languages across Africa, Asia, and the Americas (Phillipson, 1992). Such linguistic imperialism further nourished several inequities in education, as instruction in foreign languages had been detrimental to able native speakers and robbed the noble cause of multilingualism in local contexts.

In the post-colonial era, the injustices began to be recognized more and more, leading to the ever-greater formulation of international framework instruments. The UNESCO Universal Declaration on Linguistic Rights (1996) initiated the shift in paradigm because it recognized mother-tongue education as the basis of access to and quality of education. The ascent of this normative framework continued with the passage of Sustainable Development Goal 4, which directly linked inclusive education with first language instruction (UNESCO, 2016). These changes find expression in contemporary policy landscapes through:

1. Constitutional provisions for minority languages (e.g. South Africa with 11 official languages);
2. Bilingual education paradigms (for instance, Ethiopia with its 8-year mother-tongue policy);
3. Indigenous languages revitalization programmes (Māori-kura-kaupapa schools).

In practice, persistent implementation gaps undermine mother-tongue education policies, resource constraints and entrenched linguistic ideologies favouring global languages and dominant local languages continue to hinder meaningful progress of mother tongue-based education. This historical trajectory witnesses the resiliency of mother tongue uses in education and the continued battle for linguistic justice in postcolonial settings.

1.1.4. Integration of mother tongue in education

Mother tongue-based education (MTBE) significantly enhances cognitive development, critical thinking and academic achievement (Cummins, 2000; UNESCO, 2003). As a foundational instructional approach, it strengthens literacy skills and cultural identity, while promoting inclusive and equitable education (Benson, 2005; May, 2014). Extensive Research done on mother-tongue education further demonstrates its societal benefits, including linguistic diversity, preservation, cultural heritage maintenance, and student identity affirmation (García, 2009; Mohanty et al., 2009).

Challenges to proper implementation, which include language dominance, lack of resources, and negative public perception toward minority languages, hinder its development (Ricento, 2006; Skutnabb-Kangas & Dunbar, 2010). In overcoming these barriers to MTBE, supportive policies, well-equipped teachers, and culturally relevant instructional material are required (Tollefson, 2013; UNESCO, 2017).

In due course, integrating mother tongues into education serves three vital purposes: (1) enhancing educational outcomes by addressing linguistic barriers, (2) safeguarding global linguistic diversity, and fostering socially inclusive learning environments. This approach aligns fundamentally with sustainable development principles by empowering students through linguistically responsive pedagogy, thereby advancing educational equity as outlined in UNESCO's 2016 framework.

1.1.5. Advocacy for mother tongue education(MTBE)

Establishing a society that embraces MTBE is paramount to the attainment of educational equity, the conservation of cultural heritage, and the empowerment of people in social change (García, 2009; UNESCO, 2003). Research has shown that MTBE strengthens academic achievement, cultural identity, and social cohesion. To realize these benefits, a broad spectrum of advocacy must address the diverse the multifaceted implementation challenges across police, practice and community involvement.

At the policy level, the advocacy would include the legal recognition and sustainable funding of MTBE programs (UNESCO, 2008). The education frameworks must conform to international standards of linguistic rights and detailed guidelines for implementation. Teacher capacity development is equally important, consisting of training in bilingual methodologies and culturally relevant pedagogies (May, 2014). Professional development should include language-teaching skills, adaptation of curriculum, and multilingual assessment strategies.

Community involvement is also essential for the successful implementation of MTBE (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000). Curriculum design, material development, and evaluation should involve local stakeholders to facilitate cultural relevance and a sense of ownership. Community advocacy must rise to the occasion and contest linguistic biases, while showing the value of MTBE to policymakers and the public.

The synergistic integration of evidence-based policymaking, professionally trained teachers, and meaningful community engagement creates the foundational conditions for MTBE to transform the education system. These approaches translate into better academic performance, the preservation of linguistic diversity, and an extremely empowered group that is not yet enjoying its right to education. Therefore, advocating MTBE remains an educational necessity and a commitment to linguistic justice in a rapidly globalizing world.

2. Theoretical foundations of MTBE

In this review article, Mother Tongue-Based Education (MTBE) is analysed through the following pivotal theoretical lenses (Table 1). These are Linguistic Human Rights, Interdependence Hypothesis, Critical Pedagogy and Language Planning Orientations. They are used to assess their role in addressing policy design, implementation challenges and decolonial reform in multilingual education. The table reveals the aspects of mother tongue-based education, the goals, polices and challenges with references to these theoretical frameworks employed in the study. By connecting these theoretical frameworks with context-based strategies and approaches, such as policy reforms community-based initiatives, and equitable resource allocations, mother tongue-based education can excel aspirational rhetoric to become a transformative force for inclusive, sustainable development in multilingual settings.

Table 1. Mother-tongue based education: goals, policies and challenges.

Aspect	Linguistic human rights	Interdependence hypothesis	Critical pedagogy	Language planning orientations
Objective	Adherence to law; fair access to education	Cognitive advantages in which mother-tongue supports second language learning	Social justice: breaking down hierarchies of power or supremacist ideology	Language vitality and socio-political equity
Policy	Anti-discrimination laws; mother tongue based multilingual education mandates	Bilingual transition models; dual-language programs	Curriculum driven by the community; decolonial frameworks	Frameworks for status/corpus planning; policies for the language revitalisation
Challenge	Insufficient enforcement and insufficient resources	Myth: first language postpones second language acquisition	Institutional inertia; resistance to decolonisation	Tensions at the top versus the bottom; ideological disputes

2.1. Linguistic human rights theory

Linguistic Human Rights Theory asserts that mother-tongue education is a basic human right. In this regard, Skutnabb-Kangas (2000) defines the systematic suppression of mother tongues in education as “linguistic genocide”, framing it as a human right violation. This theoretical perspective is substantiating by key international legal instruments, including:

1. the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (Article 30, 1989)
2. the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (Article 14, 2007)

Contemporary scholarship increasingly bridges language rights with social justice, demanding policy reforms to dismantle institutionalized linguistic marginalization (Skutnabb-Kangas & Dunbar, 2010). This paradigm shift underscores the need to reconceptualise education systems as sites of both cultural preservation and decolonial practice.

2.2. Interdependence hypothesis

Cummins’ (2000) interdependence Hypothesis argues that proficiency in the first language (L1) strengthens second language (L2) acquisition by transferring cognitive and academic skills. Contrary to the belief that L1 instruction hinders L2 learning, the theory demonstrates how L1 proficiency supports L2 literacy and critical thinking. It emphasizes that language development is not competitive but interdependent: L1 and L2 skills grow together, enhancing one another. The evidence in favor of this theoretical proposition is quite substantial. According to Thomas and Collier (2002), students with the opportunity of working for 14 years and found that those in well-implemented bilingual programs consistently outperformed peers in early-exit transitional models. During their studies in Ethiopia, Heugh et al. (2007) also observed that students receiving sustained mother-tongue instruction through Grade 8 demonstrated superior English proficiency compared to those solely in English-immersion programs. These findings have recently been strengthened by research in neuroscience, whereby a neuroimaging study has now shown that bilingual language processing utilizes the same neural networks (Cao, 2016).

The research evidence yields three critical pedagogical implications. First, an early transition to L2 instruction disrupts the crucial scaffolding essential for academic language development, ultimately compromising both L1 and L2 proficiency. Second, a strong focus on L1 also serves to strengthen the development of bilingualism and maintain cultural and linguistic identity. This represents a critical equity consideration, especially to marginalized language communities. When education systems recognize and foster linguistic interdependence through careful program design, they build equitable pathways for multilingualism and academic success. Third, education systems that intentionally design programs leveraging these interdependence principles create more equitable pathways to multilingualism, as demonstrated by the superior academic outcomes in sustained bilingual programs compared to early-exit models (Heugh et al., 2007; Thomas & Collier, 2002). These findings collectively argue for mother tongue-based multilingual education models that systematically build on learners’ linguistic repertoires rather than treating languages as separate competencies.

2.3. Critical pedagogy

Freire's Freire (1970) stance on critical pedagogy framed mother-tongue education as a liberatory act to redress linguistic oppression, a sound pedagogical practice, and a political resistance tool. Thiong'o (1986) also argued that language carries human culture and hence teaching imposed languages is an act of cultural oppression. Therefore, reclaiming one's mother tongue is an act of decolonization, as captured in popular movements that make the case for opposing linguistic imperialism. However, hegemonic systems systematically reject such initiatives, entrenched as they are in colonial hierarchies that privilege dominant languages and epistemologies. Skutnabb-Kangas and Phillipson (2017) elucidate either how dominant languages are positioned as "neutral" or "superior" and, thereby, justify the very policies that marginalize indigenous languages even further. Heugh (2021), with African case studies, shows further evidence of these tensions in stark contrast to the instances of community-run MTBE initiatives contesting state reluctance to decentralize linguistic power. These dynamics indicate the same struggles against epistemic and institutional faces of expansionism, in which language emerges as the domain of cultural sovereignty.

2.4. Language planning orientations

Cooper (1989) framework outlines four concepts for analysing language use in strategic interventions. One key concept is status planning, which refers to policies that elevate languages to official status in domains such as education, governance, and media (Baldauf & Kaplan, 2007; Ricento, 2006); the second key concept is Corpus Planning. This involves standardizing linguistic structures to promote literacy and protect cultural heritage (Cooper, 1989), the third concept, Acquisition Planning, addresses multilingual education policy, curriculum design, and teacher training (Hornberger, 2006; Ricento, 2000). Finally, Prestige Planning aims to elevate a language's societal value through cultural promotion and advocacy. These interventions can be executed at macro levels (State policies) or micro levels (community initiatives). They require language planners and policy-makers to negotiate complex socio-political dynamics (Kaplan & Baldauf, 1997) towards bringing about linguistic equity and cultural preservation.

Ruíz's Ruíz (1984) framework clarifies three key orientations in language policy. First, language-as-problem orientation prioritizes dominant languages to address perceived threats to national cohesion caused by linguistic diversity (Grin, 2003; Mutasa, 2006). Second, language-as-right orientation views the preservation of minority languages from the standpoint of human right issues. Advocates argue it ensures access to education and public services (May, 2014; Skutnabb-Kangas & Dunbar, 2010; United Nations, 1948, 1966), aligning with international agreements like the UN Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948) and the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (1996). Third, language-as-resource paradigm focuses on multilingualism as a resource for gaining intercultural dialogue or understanding and economic growth (Grenoble & Whaley, 2006; Grin, 2003). These orientations have been found to interact with each other, essentially evident in policies that standardize the national language while revitalizing the minority ones; thus, sometimes reflecting the tension between unity and diversity in societies characterized by pluralism.

Language planning deals with contextual challenges. It requires strategies that place equilibrium between the immediate need for communication and long-term considerations of cultural continuity. Integrating theoretical insights empowers stakeholders to design policies that promote linguistic rights. Simultaneously, these policies can harness languages as tools for societal development (Grin, 2003; Ruíz, 1984). Greater comprehension of the interplay between local and global influences is necessary to ensure that policies can promote equity in view of development and intercultural exchanges, given increasing interconnections.

2.5. Interconnections and tensions between frameworks

This study consists of analysing three strands of theoretical perspectives that provide their justification for understanding mother tongue-based education (MTBE). These theoretical frameworks are linguistic

human rights, the interdependence hypothesis, and critical pedagogy. They generally address the complex relationship among language, learning, and equity in education.

The linguistic human rights framework was pioneered by Skutnabb-Kangas (2000). It posits mother tongue education as a basic human entitlement. This entailment is recognized in international conventions, such as the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (2007). Examples of its successful operation are in New Zealand's Māori-medium kura kaupapa schools (May, 2013). Another example is South Africa's post-apartheid language policies (Heugh, 2011). However, as Tupas and Lorente (2014) emphasize a critical limitation. They argue that legislation alone is insufficient without sustained commitment to implementation.

Cummins' (2000) interdependence hypothesis supplies the cognitive underpinning of MTBE, giving strength to the argument that strong first language (L1) proficiency supports second language (L2) acquisition and academic success. Neuroscientific studies by Cao (2016) and Petitto (2009) have located the neural underpinnings for this transfer, while many examples of Ethiopia's bilingual education programs provide practical evidence of its tangible benefits, including higher student retention rates compared with monolingual approaches (Heugh et al., 2007). Freire's (1970) critical pedagogy challenges these power configurations and the marginalization of languages. This framework specifically addresses language conflicts, such as the tension between English and regional languages in the Philippines, as highlighted by Dhakal (2021). Grassroots initiatives like Mexico's intercultural universities (López, 2014) could show how indigenous languages can indigenously sustain particular cultural identities but also facilitate a transfer of contemporary knowledge.

These frameworks, when integrated, create very powerful models for education reform. The Māori language revitalization efforts in New Zealand (Skerrett & Ritchie, 2021) and Bolivia plurinational schools (López, 2014) show examples of how it is possible to combine legal protections, research-informed pedagogy, and critical consciousness to create equitable learning environments. However, persistent challenges in teacher training (Benson, 2010), assessment systems (UNESCO, 2021), and policy implementation (McCarty, 2013) highlight the need for continued advocacy and reform in realizing the full impact of MTBE in practice. This synthesis on theoretical perspectives provides an adequate basis for both the promised transformation and the practical challenges posed by mother tongue-based education systems across the world.

Figure 1 shows the interrelated components of the Mother-Tongue Education (MTE) framework in their multiple functions to promote linguistically equitable pedagogy. MTE constitutes a fundamental right under both the UN Convention on the rights of the Child (UNCRC) and Sustainable Development

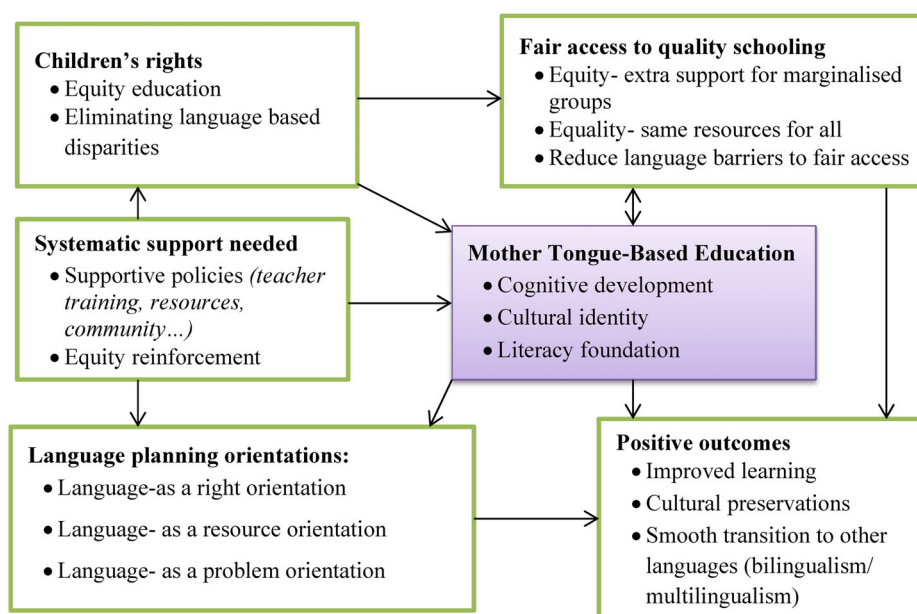


Figure 1. The interconnection of theoretical frameworks in mother tongue education.

Goal 4 (SDG4). As an equity-based approach, MTE actively addresses language-based disparities by prioritizing tailored support for linguistically marginalized groups, rather than relying on uniform resource distribution. This targeted intervention prevents linguistic alienation and ensures meaningful educational participation.

2.6. Global trends in multilingual education policy

Language policy formation has developed from colonial pasts through nationalism to current concerns of globalization. These shifts reflected unresolved conflicts between agendas favouring national unity and those safeguarding cultural identity, particularly in the struggle for educational justice. This trajectory stems from colonial policies that imposed dominant languages, marginalizing indigenous and minority languages. Such impositions entrenched systematic linguistic inequalities, displacing those communities reliant on non-native languages (Global Education Monitoring Report Team, Ndhlovu & Makalela, 2021; Piller, 2016). Hence, after independence, many countries chose to teach the dominant languages for purposes of administrative consolidation, often forgetting minority and indigenous languages (Brutt-Griffler, 2002; Enever, 2020; McCarty, 2011; Ricento, 2000).

The 20th century marked a paradigm shift toward linguistic rights and multilingual education. This trend, initiated by UNESCO, involves a mother tongue-based education. This education is emphasized as a vital for advancing equity in post-colonial societies, highlighting its role in addressing historical inequities (UNESCO, 2003, 2016). It is also observed that Bilingual and multilingual models gained support on the grounds. Research underscores their cognitive and cultural benefits while preserving heritage (Cummins, 2000; García, 2009; Heugh 2009; Mutasa, 2014). Ideological debates persist in language policy. Monolingual ones favor administrative convenience models, while multilingual ones advocate inclusivity and cognitional benefits (Baker, 2011; García, 2009). Emerging policies aim to balance between the global lingua franca (English) and local languages. However, implementation faces hurdles such as resource gaps, unprepared teachers, and political resistance (García & Kleifgen, 2010; Tollefson, 2000).

In conclusion, a feasible language policy must address past injustices, articulate educational advantages of multilingualism, and then focus on cultural preservation. UNESCO's frameworks (2003, 2017) stress multilingual education as being central for equity, identity empowerment, and global interconnectedness. Addressing these dynamics remains a critical issue for fostering inclusive and context-sensitive education policies.

2.7. Socio-political factors influencing language-in-education decisions

Language policy in education is a complex set of arrangements, with important political, social, and cultural dynamics at work. This eventually determines the prominence or suppression of indigenous languages in the world's educational systems (Phillipson, 1992; Tollefson, 2013). In this case, policymakers face challenges of harmonizing language needs across different communities while ensuring equitable access to education. Such a daunting task entails navigating socio-political landscapes for the choice of appropriate languages of instruction as per cultural diversity within a multicultural society (Ricento, 2006; Skutnabb-Kangas & Cummins, 1988).

Central to those language policy frameworks are the underlying entrenched language ideologies that shape attitudes of language use, language identity formation, and power dynamics in educational contexts (Irvine & Gal, 2000; Kroskrity, 2000). These ideologies influence the status and visibility of languages within educational contexts, reflecting power relations and norms that have historical and social backgrounds (Blommaert, 1999; Woolard, 1998). To address such ideologies, it is important to bridge them into inclusive languages in education policies that would be supportive of linguistic diversity, as well as ensuring educational access to all communities (Ricento, 2006; Skutnabb-Kangas & Cummins, 1988). Policies thereby tend to favor languages associated with political dominance or economic advantage. This often marginalizes minority and indigenous languages (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000). Research evidence indicates that education in the mother tongues or heritage languages is more beneficial for students' academic achievement as well as for cultural identity than is education only in non-native languages (Cummins, 2000).

Efforts to address linguistic disparities take two key forms. The first grassroots movement advocates for formal recognition of minority languages. Second, multilingual educational policies are implemented to ensure students can learn and thrive in their native languages (García, 2009). These educational implications stretch beyond the immediate, even so, social unity, preservation of culture, and economic opportunities are affected (Baker, 2011; García & Wei, 2014). These policies also affect students' levels of proficiency with the languages, hence post making the economic future of employment accessible or less constrained (Skutnabb-Kangas & Dunbar, 2010).

At its core, inclusive language policies in education can foster educational equity, empower marginalized communities, and cultivate culturally plural societies. Policymakers would have to consider all forms of linguistic diversity with their premises, which can promote language-in-context and put in place the necessary educational environments within which all learners can succeed academically and culturally.

3. Comparative analysis of MTBE implementation

The comparative analysis shows that there are critical lessons learned through case studies from around the globe concerning Mother Tongue-Based Education (MTBE). The policies promising both common challenges and signifying successes peculiar to particular country contexts are highlighted as seen in Table 2. For instance, Ethiopia and New Zealand excel in rural and indigenous-language implementations, respectively, with rural literacy improving in Ethiopia as well as the revival of Te Reo Māori via immersion schools in New Zealand. In contrast, Kenya and South Africa face incompletely enforced policies and a predominance of English despite the constitution recognizing multilingualism. There are geopolitical realities in India and the Philippines, where even promoting regional languages looks elitist, since it has to compete against Hindi/English ones, and also suffer from scarce material resources. Typical resistance is from elite groups with dominant language citizenship such as English, trained teachers' absence, and lack of resources (Table 2). However, on its potential, success stories evidenced MTBE show that it can boost involvement in the Philippines, culture saving in Ethiopia, and academic attainment in immersion schools for Māori. Most of the time, public views bring dualism: the theoretical support of MTBE contradicts the opinion that English is the instrument that facilitates social and economic mobility.

In general, the main lesson learned was that for MTBE to function, it requires political will, implementation dependent on the community, and support on the systemic side (ex: materials, training) to balance practical imperatives with linguistic equity. Countries like New Zealand and Ethiopia find importance in better prioritizing dotted languages, while others draw attention to the perils of symbolic policies without grassroots-aligned policies (see Table 2 for details).

3.1. Methodology: case study approaches

The study employed a rigorous methodology, integrating empirical case-study analysis with theoretical frameworks to assess MTBE policy implementations across diverse linguistic contexts. The analysis follows three primary theoretical perspectives: linguistic human rights, interdependence hypothesis, and critical pedagogy. It provides a comprehensive analysis of MTBE implementation in Ethiopia, Kenya, South Africa, New Zealand, Philippines, and India. These cases were purposively chosen based on: first, they offer rich documentation of academic achievement outcomes, and longitudinal language retention data. Second, they demonstrate measurable community involvement in language initiatives, third, they highlight unique challenges encountered during real-world implementations of mother tongue (MT) policies.

By integrating empirical case studies with theoretical lenses, the study proposes some critical considerations for the design of effective MTBE frameworks and, at a wider level, contributes to theoretical discourses around linguistic justice, cognitive advantages of L1 instruction, and decolonial perspectives in language planning for education. The dialectical approach insists on a mutually reciprocal relationship. The empirical findings deepen theoretical criticism while theoretical insights clarify the actual constraints that educators and policymakers encounter in multilingual situations. Such a dual engagement will not

Table 2. Comparative analysis of mother tongue-based education (MTBE) policies: Lessons from global case studies.

Aspect	Ethiopia	Kenya	South Africa	India	Philippines	New Zealand
Policy Framework	Education and Training Policies (1994 & 2023) mandates MTBE for primary education (Grades 1–8).	Language in Education Policy (1976) supports MTBE in early grades, but faces inconsistent implementation.	Constitution (1996) recognises 11 official languages; MTBE encouraged, but English dominates.	Three-Language Formula (1968) promotes regional languages, Hindi & English, but implementation varies by state.	MTB-MLE policy in early grades since 2009	Te Reo Māori revitalisation in education; bilingual (Māori-English) schools under Te Aho Matua
Implementation Level	Strong in rural areas, weaker in urban regions due to multilingual features/English preference	Limited to lower primary (Grades 1–3), then transitions to English	Mostly symbolic; English remains dominant in practice.	Varies by state; some prioritise regional languages, while others favour Hindi/ English	Active in public schools but limited by lack of materials and teacher training	Strong in Kura Kaupapa Māori (Māori immersion schools); optional in mainstream schools
Challenges	Resistance from elites favouring English, lack of trained teachers, resources.	Poor enforcement; shortage of MTBE-trained teachers	English hegemony; lack of political will for the expansion of MTBE	Political tensions over Hindi imposition; English seen as “elite”	Lack of standardised materials; societal preference for English	Limited to Māori communities; less emphasis in mainstream education
Successes	Improved literacy rates in rural areas; cultural preservation	Better foundational learning in MTBE schools	Some MTBE programs in indigenous languages	Strong regional language systems with high literacy outcomes	Higher student engagement in early grades; reduced dropout rates	Revitalization of Te Reo Māori; high academic achievement in immersion schools
Language Dominance	Federal languages, English (secondary school & beyond)	Swahili (national), English (official), + local languages	English (dominant), 11 official languages	Hindi (federal), English, + 22 scheduled languages.	Filipino (national), English (official), + regional languages.	English (dominant), Te Reo Māori (co-official).
Public Perception	Mixed: Urban elites prefer English; rural communities support MTBE.	Supportive in theory, but English seen as “dominant”	MTBE seen as secondary to English for economic opportunities	Highly politicised; regional pride versus Hindi/ English dominance	Positive for early grades, but English still favoured for mobility	Strong Māori community support; broader indifference in mainstream

Notes: MTB-MLE = mother tongue-based multilingual education.

only render the policy recommendations credible but also deepen our understanding of equitable language planning in global education systems.

3.2. Cross-National findings

3.2.1. Ethiopia: Long-term L1 transition model

Ethiopia's education policy framework adopts a long-term first language transition plan. Under this framework, mother-tongue education serves as the primary medium of instruction in early formal schooling. This approach fosters foundational literacy, cognitive development, and cultural identity from grades one (1) through eight (8), as stated by Heugh (2009). Rooted in multilingual contexts where local languages are designated for educational use, the policy aligns with linguistic human rights principles (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000). It guarantees the marginalized ethno-linguistic communities access to education in their heritage languages. At grade one, English appears as a subject, and in secondary schooling and beyond, it becomes a medium of instruction in rather practical terms between lingering on L1 and facing the demands of global language (Ministry of Education, Ethiopia, 1994).

The model is anchored in Ethiopia's 1994 and 2023 Education and Training Policy, which decentralizes language planning. It also gives power to regional states to develop curricula in local languages (Cohen, 2000). It implements the interdependence hypothesis, which holds that strong L1 proficiency scaffolds L2 acquisition (Cummins, 2000). Empirical studies indicate that L1 consistently enhances literacy and mastery of subjects in any given region (Heugh & Skutnabb-Kangas, 2010), while longitudinal studies reveal that youth are L1 fluent and maintain favourable cultural attitudes therein (Benson, 2005). Yet, they face great equity gaps because of the uneven distribution of resources across rural areas and shortages of trained teachers and materials in the L1 (Trudell, 2016).

Despite Ethiopia's gradual L1 transition, it is not an example of the sudden-exit models or immersion systems. It also demonstrates the feasibility of long-term L1 scaffolding in linguistically diverse, low-resource contexts (Brock-Utne, 2007). Despite advancing critical pedagogy by emphasizing marginalized languages (Freire, 1970), the model creates contradictions between ideals of linguistic justice and impediments to implementation. These social biases favour English and political dynamics linking language to ethnic identity (Smith, 2020). These challenges highlight the need for equitable resource allocation and community-led advocacy to sustain indigenous language revitalization efforts.

3.2.2. New Zealand: indigenous language revitalization

In New Zealand, the Māori language revitalization model was born out of intense grassroots activism against colonial repression of te reo Māori. Other initiatives include Te Kōhanga Reo (language-nest pre-schools) and Kura Kaupapa Māori (Māori-medium schools) where immersion in the language and culture occurs (Benton, 1997; Smith, 2020). Policy frameworks such as the Māori Language Act (1987) and Waitangi Tribunal decisions declared te reo Māori an official language and provided for its use in education and the public sector (New Zealand Government, 1987).

Indeed, the initiatives contributed to the increase of Māori speakers. In 2018, only 23% of Māori adults were reporting to speak the language at a conversational level compared to 11% in 1996 (Stats, 2021). Persistent challenges remain, including underfunded immersion schools, a shortage of teachers, and English dominance in society (May & Hill, 2005). In contrast to a gradual L1 transition model (eg., Ethiopia's approach), the New Zealand L1 immersion model places full sovereignty in the language. This model embeds the indigenous language (e.g. te reo Māori) comprehensively in education, rejecting incremental approach. Scholars frame this as decolonial efforts to reverse the language shift and reclaim cultural autonomy (Fishman, 1991).

This case reflects language revitalization as decolonial praxis (Smith, 2020) with Trudell (2016): community-based policy. Above all, this exemplifies the tension between Indigenous rights and state budgetary constraints. Similar to equity gaps observed in Ethiopia's language policies in the regions, such tensions highlight systematic challenges. Yet New Zealand's model also advances linguistic human rights by centring culturally relevant education systems (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000).

3.2.3. Philippines: Regional language programs

The Philippines' Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (MTB-MLE) policy mandates 19 regional languages as the primary medium of instruction from kindergarten to Grade 3, transitioning thereafter to Filipino and English. Grounded in linguistic human rights principles (Skutnabb-Kangas, 2000), MTBE aims to preserve heritage cultures, enhance access for ethno-linguistic minorities, and leverage foundational L1 literacy for proficiency in national and global languages (Nolasco, 2008). However, systemic barriers such as inadequate teacher training in L1 pedagogy, scarce localized materials, and societal prioritization of English as an economic gateway (Tupas, 2015) complicate implementation amid the nation's 180-language diversity. Standardized approaches risk marginalizing smaller linguistic communities despite intentions to foster complementary multilingualism.

Successful cases, such as Lubuagan, demonstrate improved early-grade literacy and student engagement through community-led curriculum development, aligning with Cummins' (2000) interdependence hypothesis on L1-L2 cognitive synergies (UNESCO, 2016; WWalter & Dekker, 2011). Unlike New Zealand's Indigenous language immersion, the Philippines' transitional model negotiates heritage revitalization with global economic demands, echoing Ethiopia's MTBE tensions between diversity and unity. This underscores the necessity for context-specific strategies addressing resource inequities, social perceptions, and systemic support to advance equitable multilingualism.

3.2.4. Kenya: Long-term L1 transition model

Kenya's Language in Education Policy (1976, 2012) employs a transitional bilingual model, using mother tongues (e.g. Kikuyu, Luo) as mediums of instruction in Grades 1–3 before abruptly shifting to English. While studies note improved foundational literacy and numeracy in MTBE schools (Gacheche, 2010; UNESCO, 2016), systemic challenges such as teacher shortages, material gaps, societal English preferences, and competition from Kiswahili/English persist (Barasa, 2023). Post-independence commissions like Ominde and Gachathi entrenched colonial legacies favoring hegemonic languages, accelerating the decline of Kenya's 40–70 Indigenous languages (Barasa, 2023; Muaka, 2011).

Programs like the Madrasa Early Childhood initiative demonstrate MTBE's potential when integrating culturally relevant content (Sifuna, 2015). However, sustainability is threatened by urban sociolinguistic shifts (e.g. Sheng dialect), regional inequities, and policy-practice misalignment. Effective MTBE requires extending mother tongue use beyond Grade 3, robust teacher training, equitable resource allocation, and societal valorization of linguistic diversity to balance globalization with cultural preservation.

3.2.5. India: Regional language programs

The Three-Language Formula of India (1968) aims to balance linguistic diversity through instruction in regional languages. Its Implementation remains uneven, however, with states like Kerala favouring robust regional systems, while others fuel political tensions by emphasizing Hindi or English dominance (National Education Policy, 2020). Despite Article 350A guaranteeing minority language rights, only 28 of India's 19,569 documented mother tongues are taught in schools (Census of Indian 2011), disproportionately excluding tribal communities and exacerbating educational inequities.

Systemic barriers such as teacher shortages, material gaps for tribal languages, and societal preferences for Hindi/English undermine linguistic equity. While the National Education Policy (2020) pledges tribal-led multilingual programs, progress remains slow. Realizing the cognitive and cultural benefits of MTBE requires urgent investment in teacher training, community-driven material development, and dismantling hegemonic language hierarchies. Such reforms must reconcile cultural-linguistic preservation with national integration, ensuring equitable access without compromising India's pluralistic ethos.

3.2.6. South Africa's indigenous language revitalization: Policy gaps and pathways

South Africa's post-apartheid Constitution (1996) enshrines 11 official languages, including isiZulu, isiXhosa, and Sesotho, framing mother tongue-based education (MTBE) as a mechanism for equity and decolonization. However, English retains institutional hegemony in education and governance, relegating indigenous languages to symbolic roles despite constitutional mandates (Madonsela, 2012). Systemic barriers such as a limited political will, underfunding, and scarce standardized materials hinder MTBE

implementation for languages. Public perceptions of English as critical for economic mobility further marginalize indigenous language schooling, reflecting postcolonial tensions between linguistic diversity and global language dominance (Magocha et al., 2019; Singh, 2014).

Constitutional language rights clash with realities in urban schools, where English dominates instruction, and in higher education, where indigenous languages are sidelined due to resource shortages, teacher inadequacies, and complex multilingual demographics (Mutasa, 2006). In this regard, Ogutu and Nthiga (2008) state that with sufficient political will, language policies could be adjusted to better support African languages. However, major challenges persist due to a lack of resources. The authors note that policymakers frequently cite several obstacles, including a shortage of qualified teachers proficient in African languages and trained in mother tongue instruction, poor teaching resources, an underdeveloped terminology, and limited capacity to address modern scientific and technological concepts.

MTBE debates remain polarized. Proponents cite enhanced learning outcomes, while critics caution against tribalism or academic dilution (Magocha et al., 2019). Exceptions like the Nal'ibali Xhosa literacy campaign and university-led models (Mkhize & Balfour, 2017) demonstrate the efficacy of community-driven MTBE. Scholars advocate for systemic reforms prioritizing teacher training, material development, and substantive policy shifts to address inequities. A critical reassessment of language ideologies is essential to align educational practices with constitutional multilingualism, reconciling South Africa's linguistic heritage with its decolonial aspirations.

3.3. Policy-Practice gaps In language education: a comparative summary

Research affirms that mother tongue education (MTE) enhances literacy, cognitive development, and multilingual transitions (Cummins, 2000; UNESCO, 2008). Yet systemic barriers—chronic underfunding, teacher shortages, and sociocultural biases favoring dominant languages—undermine policy implementation globally (Benson, 2005; May, 2014). Ethiopia's sustained L1 instruction (Grades 1–8) boosts achievement but falters in rural areas due to material scarcity and underqualified teachers (Trudell, 2016). Similarly, New Zealand's Māori revitalization, though increasing speakers, contends with English hegemony and funding deficits (May & Hill, 2005; Stats, 2021). In the Philippines, MTB-MLE grapples with parental English preferences and minority-language material gaps (Tupas, 2015), while Kenya's abrupt post-Grade 3 English transition entrenches colonial linguistic hierarchies (Muaka, 2011). India's Three-Language Formula neglects tribal communities, teaching only 28 of 19,569 languages (Census of India, 2011; Ministry of Human Resource Development, Department of School Education & Literacy 2016; National Education Policy, 2020), and South Africa's constitutional multilingualism clashes with English dominance (Ogutu & Nthiga, 2008).

Colonial legacies, resource inequities, and global language biases perpetuate these challenges. Successful models, such as Ethiopia's L1 scaffolding and New Zealand's decolonial praxis (Smith, 2020), underscore the efficacy of community-driven approaches, teacher training, and equitable investment. Addressing these gaps requires systemic reforms that harmonize linguistic rights with material support, enabling marginalized languages to thrive alongside global lingua francas.

4. Policy implications and recommendations

4.1. Framework for context-sensitive MTBE design

Mother Tongue-Based Education (MTBE) requires policy frameworks that combine pedagogical firmness with local linguistic realities for proper implementation. The lessons from Ethiopia, New Zealand, and the Philippines underscore three broad principles (Magocha et al., 2019; Singh, 2014). First, strong legal and policy frameworks must explicitly justify MTBE and allow regional language options. South Africa's constitutional mandate for multilingual education serves as a key example. However, implementation has been inconsistent, revealing gaps between policy intent and practice (Madonsela, 2012; Ogutu & Nthiga, 2008). Second, the structure of curricula might desire sustained mother-tongue instruction for 6-8 years before introducing bilingual models. This extended timeframe ensures foundational literacy and cognitive development of students in their first languages. Moreover, standardized teaching

materials must be developed and distributed in indigenous languages to support equitable learning outcomes. Third, involvement in the community co-design should be emphasized, as in the New Zealand case of whānau school governance, or with local curriculum committees in Ethiopia. These pillars must correspondingly address the political and economic dimensions of language policy. This requires allocating dedicated funding for teacher training programs and localized material development. Concurrently, accountability must be ensured through national monitoring standards to track progress and resource utilization. Context-sensitive MTBE explicitly turns against universal blueprint and demands localized, pre-implementation diagnostic assessments of language vitality, teacher preparedness, and community desires to warrant culturally informed answers.

4.2. Future directions for research and practice

There are three critical areas needing attention in emerging frontiers in Mother Tongue-Based Education (MTBE). First, pedagogic research should mainly focus on experimental studies concerning the use of technology in tutoring systems and hybrid models (for example, online-community language nests) that aim at revitalizing marginalized languages (Mkhize & Balfour, 2017). At the same time, innovative research that establishes flexible frameworks for addressing urban multilingualism is needed. Frameworks that will go beyond the rigid mother tongue/second language dichotomy (Singh, 2014). Secondly, the funds to support these policy reforms should be sustainable, as in the case of Indonesia with its fiscal transfers to local language programs or Mexico with its intercultural universities, which embed Indigenous knowledge into higher education. The last rule in implementation science must intercede on the systemic gaps in teacher preparation, such as micro-credentialing systems and experimental pedagogies.

Longitudinal mixed-methods research will dynamically warrant tracking cognitive outcomes and identity formation across various stages of education. Viable pilot activities like mobile teacher networks to rural areas, digital repositories for minoritized languages, and South-South policy partnerships could catalyze solutions toward scaling them. Together, these would help address persistent inequities between empirically documented benefits of MTBE and its fair and equitable worldwide implementation, enhancing inclusive linguistic and educational justice.

5. Conclusion

Mother tongue-based education advances equity in education, cultural reclamation, and inclusive development. The case studies from all over the world prove that it does both, giving benefit to efficiency in pedagogy and empowerment to culture. Its continued L1 instruction has enhanced literacy as well as cognitive condition in Ethiopia, but glaring rural-urban resource disparities at the vision in addition to social biases that privilege the dominant language (e.g. English) underscore the need for equal training and material access for teachers. Similarly, New Zealand's Māori revitalization, supported by the Māori Language Act, exemplifies grassroots decolonizing initiatives, though underfunding and English's hegemony persist.

Transitional models in Kenya and the Philippines privilege dominant languages, such as English, Filipino, to attain very limited short-term literacy gains at the expense of Indigenous languages. It reflects the much bigger tension of immediate benefits vis-a-vis that of linguistic equity in the long run. The case of India's inconsistent Three Language Formula and the South African constitutional multilingualism-overshadowed by English's dominance, further highlights systemic inequalities rooted in colonial legacies. Interventions such as the Nal'ibali campaign of South Africa can easily challenge these trends through the establishment of community-led local-language literacy programs.

With resource capacity challenges and teacher capacity shortfalls, MTBE has still shown success in fostering academic achievement and cultural identity. Ethiopia's federalist language policy and the MTB-MLE programs of the Philippines promote decentralized approaches with culturally relevant materials and redress historical marginalization. Community-driven models (Kenya), tribal-led interventions (India), and hybrid approaches (South Africa) have all demonstrated systemic change pathways by centering local agency. Certainly, MTBE goes beyond pedagogy; it is a reparative framework for deleting

and addressing erasure. All this in the embedding of linguistic diversity within education and challenging all colonial hierarchies, thereby affirming marginalized identities, reclaiming cultural heritage, and making inclusive societies where all learners will thrive.

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